

Ethnography Field Notes Reflection

Observing the class during this activity was an interesting and honestly entertaining experience, since the UNO games could get a little energetic and spirited at times. Sometimes I had some trouble staying an observer because the participants were so interactive and animated that I couldn't help but jump in. Still, I made sure to observe everyone and take notes. For my notetaking, I was focusing on how the groups resolved conflict. I was staying alert for situations where there would be negative emotions, words, or actions between participants, but I found that the conflicts were often accompanied by laughter and joking instead. Thus, my assumption was wrong and I had to shift my focus to those situations instead.

For the notes themselves, I usually summarized what people did; for example, "X threw away a +2 card" or "A gave B two more cards and B did not protest". I wasn't able to write down any direct quotes as the conversations were too fast for me to keep up. I also didn't compile my notes afterwards since we moved pretty quickly into the group discussion. Next time, I would try to write more direct quotes, maybe by switching my medium of notetaking (I type really fast on a computer keyboard as opposed to a phone or writing by hand). I would also try to make time to reflect and compile my notes, as this will help summarize the experience and draw general conclusions about the experience.

This experience emphasized the skills of observation, perception, and listening, which are all skills that more people could work on, in my opinion. People tend to be self-centered and self-interested, which isn't always a bad thing as it is simply human nature. However, taking the time to observe situations outside of yourself and truly act as a "fly on the wall" can help reveal a lot about human behaviors and group dynamics. This information can help me understand the people I willingly or unwillingly surround myself with, which can lead to better communication

and reduction of conflict or misunderstandings. Maybe I observe and realize that I don't even like these group dynamics and I leave them! Whatever I learn from my observation.

My final takeaways are that observation can be an important tool for learning the behaviors and dynamics of a group of people. For effective observation, I have to take detailed and accurate field notes that objectively describe what is happening, then reflect on my notes and the events that I witnessed. In a world where everyone wants attention, sometimes you have to stop and pay attention to the world.